notambourine

INTERNAL LEARN

the cost of being *wrong*

Why the fear of a miss costs more than the miss.

OCTOBER 2026

Fear of being wrong costs more than being wrong.

AGENDA

four ideas, one *thesis*

1. Expected value: price the bet, not the outcome
2. Queues: why waiting is never free
3. Amdahl's law: why faster coding barely moves the ticket
4. How fear asks for control, and where to hold the line

good players lose most *hands*

Poker doesn't score a hand as right or wrong. It scores the decision: how often it wins and what it pays, against how often it loses and what that costs.

EV = win rate × payoff **−** miss rate × cost

how often it lands, what it pays

how often it misses, what it costs

win rate is half the *math*

33%

wins needed to break even on a pot-sized call: risk 1 to win 2

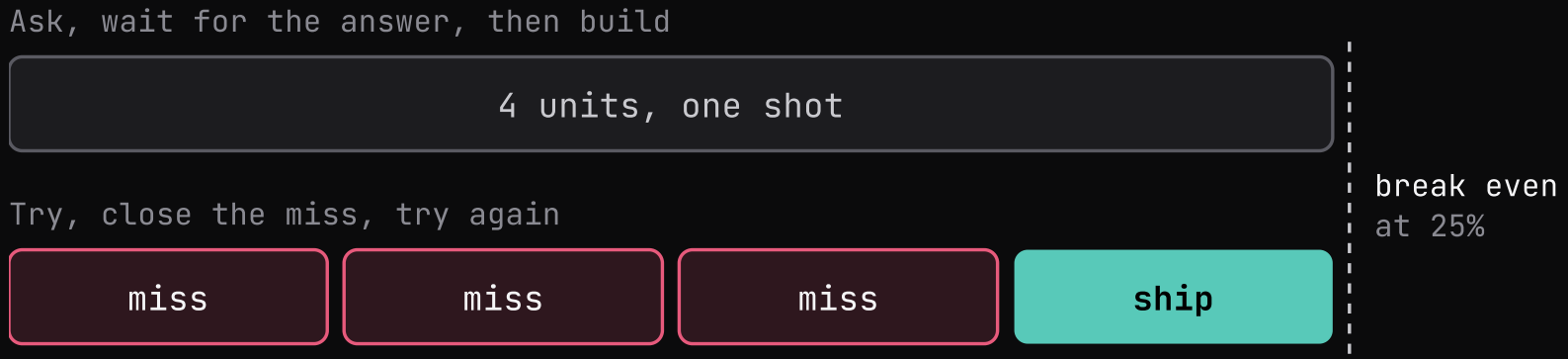
25%

wins needed when a try costs a quarter of the wait it replaces

You don't need to be right. You need the wins to pay for the misses.

trying 4x cheaper means right *1 in 4*

Four tries cost one wait, so 25% breaks even. Misses teach, so later tries land more.



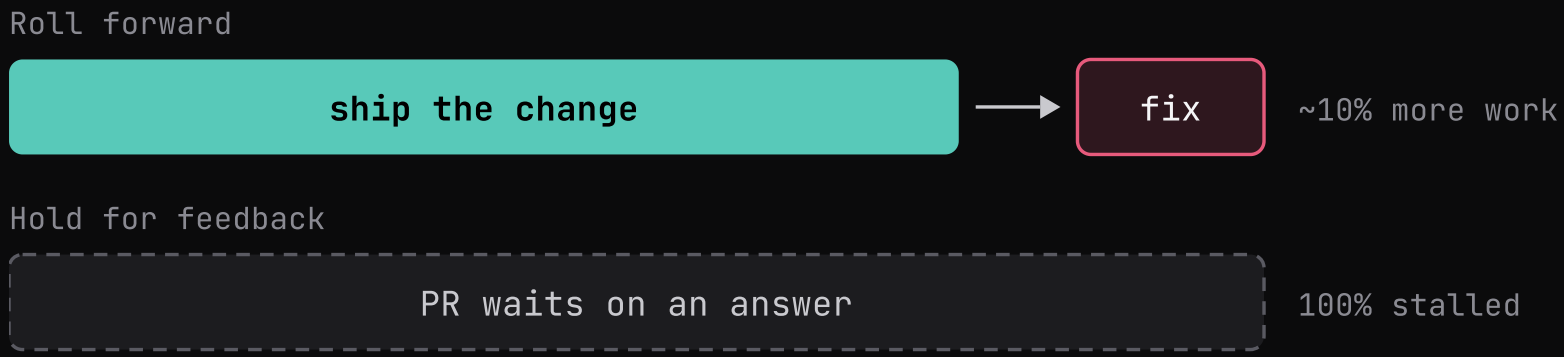
Illustrative units

"what if it's wrong?" is the wrong *question*

- **"What if it's wrong?"** Close it. A miss costs a look and a close.
- **"What do I point it at?"** Everything. Keep what lands.
- A miss shows where the ticket was unclear. That is something to pick up on.
- This holds while closing a miss stays cheap. Keep tries small.

a fix costs *10%*, a hold costs 100%

A wrong change costs a follow-up ticket. Holding the PR for feedback stalls all of it.



Same for an undo: recommend it after the work, don't ask before it.

"waiting is free" until you see the *queue*

A blocked ticket looks free: you pick up another. But parked work raises lead time for every ticket.

lead time = **work in progress** ÷ **throughput**

rises for everyone

+1 per parked ticket

stale PRs, rebases, rebuilt context

set by the team

Little's law

the coding speeds up, and *one* step of nine moves



2x faster build, *10%* faster ticket

The speedup is capped by the part you didn't speed up.



A known small loss beats an unknown long wait.

06 / FEAR AND CONTROL

four ways fear asks for *control*

inaction is also a *decision*

We scrutinize the consequences of acting more than the consequences of not acting.

> "If I approve this and it fails, that's attributable to me. If I delay it, the lost opportunity is hard to attribute."

make the cost of delay *visible*

A wrong decision produces a visible failure; delay produces diffuse lost time, momentum, and opportunity.

> "The downside I'm preventing is measurable. The cost I'm creating by waiting probably won't be."

requests for certainty are *resource* requests

Asking a question is cheap; answering it can require substantial work from other people.

> "There is almost no marginal cost to me in asking for one more analysis."

the person buying certainty should confront its *price*

The requester captures the safety/reputational value of additional certainty; the organization absorbs the loss of speed.

> "More confidence makes my decision safer. The resulting slowdown belongs to everyone."

one-way doors get the *slow* lane

If you can't undo it in an hour, slow down: ask, review, test. Everything else rolls forward.

- Data migrations
- Auth and permissions
- Billing and payments
- Public launches

CLOSE

think about *these*

1. Expected value over certainty
2. Queues over idle time
3. Amdahl over raw speed

Where do they show up in your work, especially at handoffs outside the team?

How we work